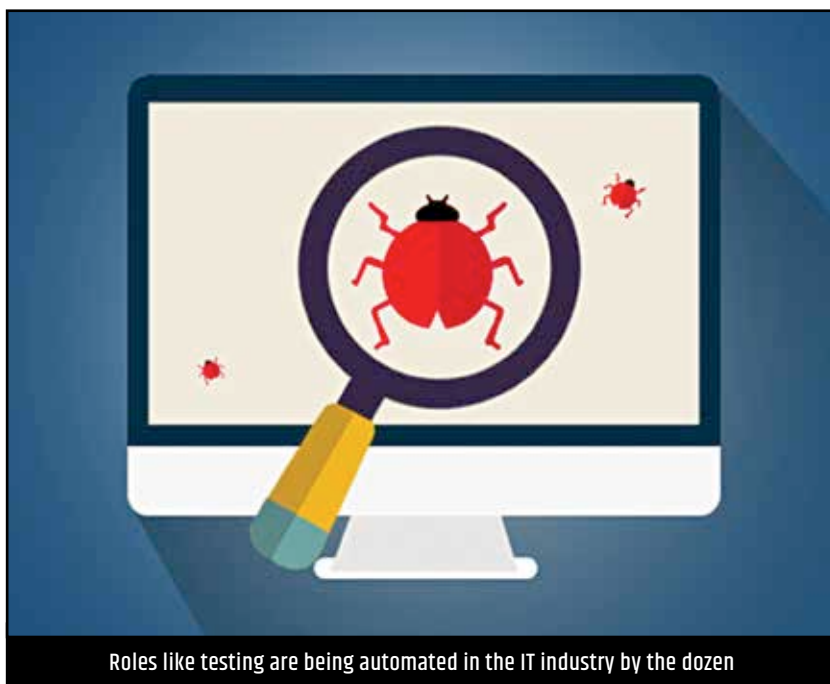




to become a part of our reality in the near future, a more important picture that it intends to paint is that AI is gradually taking over jobs around the world, and India is no different. Except where it actually is different – the kind of jobs at risk here. It is not news that AI and automation have caused and will cause job cuts, but the question we need to ask right now is, which jobs are at risk and what can we do about it? The answer, as it turns out, is neither easy, nor pretty.

IT's already happening

Knowing how to code has been one of the sure shot ways in India to get a job. India produces more engineers every year than the entire population of Bahrain. But if you ask any fresher in the IT and software industry, especially the ones working at firms that are known for mass recruitment, they will tell you that the average salary of a fresher hasn't really gone up in the last 7-8 years. Ironically, 65 percent of the global IT work is off-shored to India, as is 40 percent of business processes. The reason behind the stagnating salary is the mostly stagnating level of work that

gets outsourced to India – legacy work based on older software that is broken down to a granular level. That is exactly the kind of work that modern day AI has been designed to automate – and it's doing that quite well. Sadly, we don't have the skill or a plan to deal with it.

While it is wrong to say that there's going to be a doomsday like scenario where everyone in IT loses their jobs overnight and is out on the streets, it's not going to be a bed of roses either. Earlier, a growth of, say, 9 percent in the IT industry would correspond to a similar growth in recruitment. But right now, that number is more likely to hit 4 to 5 percent each year with most outsourced tasks like testing, customer service and more being automated. And it is not just purely software-based roles we are talking about here.

Take the example of Cisco's Application Centric Infrastructure offering. The company built a 'controller' layer between the application and the infrastructure that can

be coded with business policies. As and when required, this layer can instruct the infrastructure appropriately to 'heal itself', rendering well-paid middle level infrastructure jobs like system administrators, database admins, network engineers useless or required only for manual intervention when all else fails. Overall, jobs are going to be fewer and quite specialised in IT in the coming years.

On the ground

And it's not just about IT. According to a World Bank report, almost 70 percent of the Indian workforce will be irrelevant soon. This is likely to happen in sectors like manufacturing, agriculture, security services and logistics. So along with the large chunk of mid-level jobs, a segment of lower-rung jobs are also at risk.

India's recent push towards manufacturing through the 'Make in India' movement has shown promise in terms of projects being undertaken in the country. But as anyone with a basic understanding of economics would tell you, that for a developing nation, a growing manufacturing sector generating equal growth in employment is crucial for that nation to eventually become a developed nation. In this case, that trend is gradually looking a bit precarious.

Going by data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy, between 1997-98 and 2011-12, the percentage of people employed in the manufacturing sector has declined

